



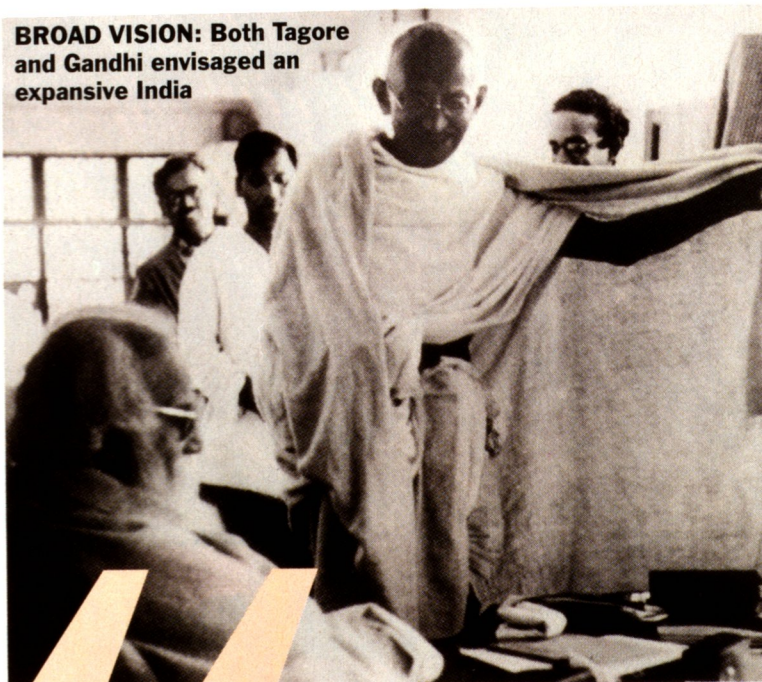
purveyors of Hindutva have developed an obsessive interest in replacing Tagore's invocation of multitudes under the watchful eye of divinity with a lyric they read as more homogeneous and signifying the triumph of one religion's claim to nation over all others. Like all forces who sense that their claim to ownership of nation is not as absolute as they would like it to be, Hindutvawadis have also attempted to force the singing of the hymn in schools. Presumably, a more genuine and heartfelt commitment to national community would not require such authoritarian insistence.

At stake here are precisely two different conceptions of unity. Bankim's lyrics were written in 1882 when nationalism itself was at a very nascent stage of development and when a larger nation beyond Bengal was yet to be widely discussed. Critics have rightly read the Muslim enemy in *Ananda Math* as a partial stand-in for the English rulers that Bankim, a civil servant, did not dare openly criticise. His was not a vision for a new society but an imagining of self-assertion in the face of subjection. In a post-colonial society, such defensive self-assertion may well be anachronistic.

For Tagore, as time went on, it became clear that a narcissistic and reactive nationalism which simply pitted the Self against an alien Other would necessarily be limited and even self-destructive. In his famous lectures on nationalism, he tried to envisage a more expansive India leading the way to global human community in contrast to what he saw as the aggressive self-love of warring patriotisms in the West, still reeling from World War I. His judgement was unambiguous: only those who deployed the "moral power of love and vision of spiritual unity" and not "those who are constantly developing their instincts for fight and intolerance of aliens" would be fit to take "their permanent place in the age that is lying before us".

This was a startlingly courageous observation at a time when narrow nationalism was becoming the received vocabulary of international politics. Tagore rejected colonialism as itself a product of narrow national self-interest. But he understood that the new India coming into being would be best served by uniqueness, not by shabby imitation of existing models. "We cannot borrow other people's history," he writes. Fluidity was integral to Indian history; it would be essential to remain open to change and growth, to expand one's conceptual borders. The recent call to delete 'Sind' and replace it with 'Kashmir' indicates an exceptionally reductive reading of the anthem which envisages a generous diversity not mandated only by inter-

BROAD VISION: Both Tagore and Gandhi envisaged an expansive India



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national law and political borders.

My Chinese friend is right. Sixty years on, there is much to admire in post-colonial India, not least those traditions of engagement that have survived many historical assaults, including some in recent times and most notably during the long midnight of the Emergency. They need to be guarded not only from the assaults of chauvinists across the spectrum but also from the equally serious dangers of indifference to politics and civic engagement. Curiously, China's Me-Pod generation is said to be upholding the repressive status quo because they are too busy consuming prosperity to question its actions or to worry about their more vulnerable rural compatriots. We too face a similar danger where frenzied individualist consumerism has made indifference to politics and to the lives of others acceptable, even fashionable. If our claims to national community are to be more than ritualistic and hollow, it is to a vision of actively democratic, egalitarian and plural nationhood that we must renew our commitment.



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